

Emotional representation: Identifying the characteristics and consequences of elected officials mirroring the emotions of their constituents

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Abstract

This study examines which elected officials are most likely to mirror their constituents' emotions in public outreach—a concept we term *emotional* representation. We also analyze the significance of emotional representation for the targeted group. To accomplish these goals, we examine the degree to which members of Congress mirrored Black people's documented increase in expressions of anger following the murder of George Floyd in the summer of 2020. Using a regression discontinuity design and the sentiment analysis of 305,358 tweets, 190,192 Facebook Posts, and 35,409 press releases, we show that descriptive representatives provide the highest levels of emotional representation. To examine the impact of emotional representation, we deployed a two-stage experiment to 390 Black respondents. We find that Black people who increased in anger after being primed with images of police violence view elected officials who engage in emotional representation as more favorable, empathetic, and trustworthy.

INTRODUCTION

Elected officials are often judged by the issues they choose to discuss in their public outreach (Mendez & Grose, 2018; Milita et al., 2014; Simas et al., 2021). Missteps in position-taking or ignoring crucial moments can jeopardize re-election (Simas et al., 2021). The decision to speak about a topic is a demonstrably important one. Yet, how members speak out is underexamined in social science research (but see Klofstad, 2016; Stephens-Dougan, 2020; Dietrich et al., 2019; Zárates, 2023). In addition to speaking out, it is likely important to constituents that elected officials convey the appropriate emotional tone in their response to salient events. Shared emotional responses to the same stimuli have the potential to create a stronger relationship between the public and Members of Congress.

Previous research shows that individuals can express empathy with others through emotional mirroring (Chartrand & Van Baaren, 2009; McIntosh, 2006). As a result, we anticipate that elected officials who match the emotions of their constituents can imbue a sense of shared understanding. This, in turn, could improve constituents' perceptions of the elected official's trustworthiness and responsiveness. By exploring emotional mirroring in public outreach, this study makes an important contribution to our understanding of the subtle ways that elected officials can strengthen the link between themselves and those they represent. To identify who matches the dominant emotions of their constituents and under what conditions, we examine the case study of how elected officials responded to the Black populations' documented increase in anger following the murder of George Floyd in May of 2020. While often reticent to display signs of anger (Phoenix, 2019), African Americans expressed significant indignation following Floyd's murder. Eichstaedt et al. (2021) found through an analysis of a panel survey that in the weeks following Floyd's death, the number of African Americans expressing feelings of anger grew significantly more relative to other groups.

The dramatic documented change in Black people's expressions of anger following the murder of George Floyd (Eichstaedt et al., 2021) provides a unique opportunity to explore which elected officials were the most likely to match the emotions of the Black community during this pivotal period. We suspect that descriptive representatives (i.e., representatives who share the race of their constituents) will be the most likely to match African Americans' increase in anger given their shared personal experiences around race (Brown, 2014; Grose, 2011; Minta, 2011; Tate, 2003). By publicly mirroring the emotions collectively felt by African Americans, Black officeholders can affirm their ties to their shared race constituency while signaling their attentiveness to issues facing their racial in-group.

In this study, we explore whether Black members of Congress mirror the Black population's documented increase in anger more than non-Black legislators following the murder of George Floyd. To accomplish this goal, we connect theories of emotions in politics to literature on descriptive representation. We first discuss the general significance of anger to politics, the nexus of anger and race, and why anger was the dominant emotion of African Americans following George Floyd's death. We then review literature explaining why Black representatives' shared experiences, stronger co-racial networks, and general concern about the Black community should increase their likelihood of matching Black people's anger following the murder of George Floyd. Finally, we discuss why emotional mirroring should shape voters' assessments of elected officials.

To test our hypotheses, we explore which elected officials displayed the highest levels of anger in their public communication following the murder of George Floyd using a regression discontinuity design and the sentiment analysis of 305,358 Tweets, 190,192 Facebook Posts, and 35,409 press releases for over 400 members of the 116th US House of Representatives (2019–2021). We find that members of Congress, regardless of their race, use significantly more anger-based words in their Tweets, Facebook posts, and press releases immediately after the murder of George Floyd. This shows that all members mirrored changes in the population's reactions to Floyd's death. However, we demonstrate that the growth in anger-based words is significantly greater among Black elected officials, mirroring changes in the Black population.

We then explore whether emotional matching matters in African Americans' assessment of elected officials by deploying a two-stage experiment to a sample of 400 African Americans using Prolific. Our experimental analysis confirms that African Americans who increased in their anger when presented with evidence of police violence are more approving of a hypothetical elected official who mirrors that emotion. They are also more likely to believe that the elected official who displays anger cares about them and, in some cases, will work to advance their interests in government relative to elected officials who use sadness in their outreach or provide no outreach at all. These trends suggest that elected officials who mirror the emotions

of their audience send meaningful signals of credibility and empathy. Accordingly, mirroring the emotions of constituents constitutes an effective form of engagement that can enhance the empowering effects of descriptive representation.

EMOTIONS IN POLITICS AND THE RACIAL BOUNDS OF ANGER FOR BLACK ELECTED OFFICIALS

The death of George Floyd at the hands of Minneapolis police officers significantly altered the emotional state of the nation (Pressman et al., 2022). While a broad swath of Americans were shocked by this event, the emotional effect was most profound among African Americans who report feeling particularly affected by incidents of police violence against Black individuals (McGowen & Wylie, 2020) and disproportionately experience negative interactions with law enforcement (Hurwitz et al., 2015). Consistent with this idea, Eichstaedt et al. (2021) draw from a panel survey of over 100,000 Americans conducted during 2020 to demonstrate that African Americans displayed significantly more anger in the week following the murder of George Floyd than the month before.

The percentage of Black respondents that expressed feelings of anger grew substantially from 22.3% in the month before Floyd's murder to 47.7% in the week following his murder. This 25.4% increase in the number of Black people displaying anger was significantly greater than the 11% increase in Whites' expressing feelings of anger over the same period. Moreover, anger was both the fastest growing and most common emotion among African Americans in the weeks after Floyd's murder (Eichstaedt et al., 2021).

Anger is an emotion with particular relevance to American politics. When feeling angry, individuals rely more strongly on their predispositions, become less risk averse, and experience increased motivation to correct the perceived norm violation (Huddy et al., 2007; Marcus et al., 2000). Anger motivates people to take immediate action. Multiple studies demonstrate a positive association between feeling angry over politics and political participation (Carver, 2004; Phoenix, 2019; Roseman, 2011; Valentino et al., 2009; Valentino & Neuner, 2017). The mobilizing effects of anger are in many cases larger than the effects of other emotions, such as fear or enthusiasm (Valentino et al., 2011).

At the same time, not all groups' anger is judged equally. In particular, African Americans may feel inhibited from expressing anger, as the conflation of Black people with longstanding tropes of criminality and violence means that being Black and angry carries potential for increased stigmatization (Phoenix, 2019). Black public figures are also prone to being labeled with the "angry Black" stereotype, potentially diminishing their credibility and standing among the White public (Phoenix, 2019; Stephens-Dougan, 2020). For instance, Banks and White (2024) find that White people penalize Black officeholders who express anger with lower vote likelihoods. Given this relationship, mirroring the Black populations' documented increase in anger carries significant electoral risks for Black politicians; however, it may be especially important to Black constituents given the social sanctions they face for expressing this emotion.

LINK BETWEEN DESCRIPTIVE REPRESENTATION, SHARED EMOTIONS, AND EVALUATIONS OF ELECTED OFFICIALS

We believe that there are multiple pathways that should lead descriptive representatives to be more likely to mirror the dominant emotions of co-racial/ethnic people in the population following the murder of George Floyd. The first and most likely explanation for emotional

mirroring is that Black legislators will respond similarly to the same stimuli as Black people in the population. Previous research demonstrates that Black people tend to have a more uniform negative reaction to information about police brutality (Alang et al., 2021; Hall, 2022; McLeod et al., 2020). Given their own experiences with discrimination, the Floyd murder likely engendered anger among Black politicians in a manner similar to African Americans in the population.

For example, Black US Senator Tim Scott (SC-R) spoke about the high number of times he was stopped by law enforcement as an elected official, "In the course of one year, I've been stopped seven times by law enforcement, Not four, not five, not six, but seven times in one year as an elected official."¹ That even African Americans in powerful institutional positions continue to face personal discrimination from police officers may make them angry to hear of in-group members facing the same circumstances (Dawson, 1995).

Similarly, Black elected officials may feel angry about Floyd's murder because they feel a more personal connection to Floyd and his family due to their shared racial identity. Black Congresswoman Frederica Wilson (FL-D) spoke about how she felt fear for those she was close to when watching the video of Floyd's murder.

For generations, countless Black mothers and fathers have held their breath each time their sons left home, out of fear that they might be targeted by the police simply because of the color of their skin... my heart broke when I heard [Floyd] calling out for his mama, who died just two years ago. It shook me to the core because I have a Black son and I know that he would have been calling for me.²

Personal experience and the ability to empathize with Floyd, Breonna Taylor, Tyre Nichols, and others may make it so that Black elected officials' personal reactions to police violence are no different from their co-racial constituents. This may lead Black elected officials to naturally mirror the emotions of African Americans in their public communication immediately following the murder of George Floyd.

Another possible pathway to explain the link between descriptive representation and shared emotions is that Black legislators mirror the emotions of their constituents to build a stronger connection with those who share their race (Hess & Fischer, 2014; Hess et al., 2014; Kopelman et al., 2006). Indeed, previous research shows that Black public officials consistently affirm their commitment to advancing the particular needs of African Americans—both those within and beyond their respective jurisdictions (Brown, 2014; Tate, 2003; Wamble, 2024). And they seek avenues to advance policies in line with Black demands, even in lower-publicized settings or when they face no electoral incentive to do so (Baker & Cook, 2005; Broockman, 2013; Grose, 2011; Lowande et al., 2019; Minta, 2011). This work indicates that Black elected officials are intrinsically motivated to assist those who share their race.

While less likely given that emotional matching is often unconscious (Chartrand & Van Baaren, 2009; McIntosh, 2006), it is possible that the emotional mirroring observed among descriptive representatives is tied to efforts to reflect the emotions collectively experienced by African Americans. This public expression serves to affirm and legitimize Black emotions—especially anger, which is often stigmatized within broader society (Phoenix, 2019). Black elected officials may view this amplification as especially vital if they perceive the risks that African Americans run for public expressions of their anger. Such an effort to not only amplify

¹<https://www.cnn.com/2016/07/13/politics/tim-scott-police-racial-profiling/index.html>.

²<https://wilson.house.gov/media-center/press-releases/wilson-statement-on-the-passage-of-the-george-floyd-justice-in-policing>.

but validate the sentiment of Black people would be consistent with previous research that shows that Black elected officials go the extra mile to advance the interests of their constituents (Williams, 2000).

One final explanation for the stronger link between descriptive representation and emotional mirroring is tied to emotional contagion. Previous research demonstrates that people adapt their moods to those around them (Chmiel et al., 2011; Kramer et al., 2014). When people are in contact with a large number of angry people, for example, their mood changes to match those within their environment (Coviello et al., 2014). This emotional contagion is most common among individuals who share the same political values (Homan et al., 2023).

Broockman (2014) shows that citizens are more likely to contact elected officials who share their racial identity. Moreover, Grose et al. (2007) find that Black legislators often hire more Black staffers and surround themselves with Black advisors. Black legislators' increased interactions with co-racial individuals who may be experiencing heightened anger following Floyd's murder could potentially influence the legislators themselves, leading to elevated levels of anger among them in response to this significant event.

Regardless of the source, an extensive body of research demonstrates the spillover effects of emotions and particularly anger (Sears et al., 2016; Yeghyan, 2015). Anger may arise from a single source; but once present, this emotion often seeps over to a broader set of targets (Sears et al., 2016). Accordingly, Black people's anger about the murder of Floyd likely ignited a general sense of frustration with other areas of society and politics. As a result, we anticipate that the most comprehensive displays of emotional matching in the wake of Floyd's murder will include anger-based language in a wider set of issues than just Black Lives Matter. This outreach would more genuinely reflect how anger operates among aggrieved individuals. While we are not able to identify the exact reason why Black legislators match the emotions of those who share their racial identity, overall this research leads us to expect...

H1. Black legislators will best reflect Black people's increase in anger in their public communication following the murder of George Floyd.

We expect that voters will be more approving of elected officials who mirror their emotions during salient events. Research details the importance of emotional mirroring in the development of attitudes toward others (Chartrand & Van Baaren, 2009; McIntosh, 2006). When individuals are emotionally matched, they are more trusting of the matcher, feel that the matcher is more empathetic, and are more likely to feel a bond with the matcher (Maddux et al., 2008). Moreover, individuals are more likely to rate emotional matchers as being better leaders and more persuasive (Van Swol & Drury, 2008). Additionally, when an individual is emotionally matched, they feel validated in their feelings rather than ostracized for their reactions (Stel et al., 2008).

This sense of feeling heard often translates into more approval for the emotional matcher. Based on this research, we anticipate that people will be more approving of elected officials who match their emotions in their public outreach. Given that other forms of mirroring such as dialect, attire, and speech patterns are often associated with an increase in approval for elected officials (Fenno, 1977, 2003; Klofstad, 2016), we suspect that emotional matching should also motivate positive feelings about elected officials. Thus, our second hypothesis states...

H2. Legislators who match the dominant emotions of an individual should be perceived more positively across a host of measures.

EMOTIONS AND DIFFERENT FORMS OF POLITICAL COMMUNICATION

To examine emotional mirroring among elected officials following the murder of George Floyd, we focus on their public communication. While one could measure change in emotions by other means such as facial expressions, brain activity, or heart rate, we believe that public communication more efficiently captures the signals constituents receive about their elected officials' sentiments. Moreover, public communication provides real-time information for how legislators respond to critical events that are accessible to the public.

To examine the sentiment in communication, we collected the universe of Tweets for 410 US House Representatives (94.2%), Facebook posts for 400 US House Representatives (91.9%), and press releases for 408 US House Representatives out of 435 US House Members (93.8%) in the 116th US Congress (2019–2021). The only representatives for whom we do not have data are those who did not tweet, put out a Facebook post, or a press release during our period of interest, those who did not have a Twitter or Facebook account, or whose sites could not be accessed (Kearney, 2019; Wickham, 2016).³ Those for whom we do have data are statistically not different from the complete US House of Representatives with regard to race, partisanship, gender, and district demographics (see [online Appendix](#)). In all, our data set includes 305,358 Tweets, 190,192 Facebook posts, and 35,409 press releases from our period of interest, which ranges from 6 months before the video of the murder of George Floyd was public (November 27, 2019) to 6 months following this event (November 27, 2020).

The combination of Twitter, Facebook, and press release data provide a comprehensive view of verbal communications for members of Congress. Previous research demonstrates that press releases are the main form of communication that members of Congress use to broadcast their positions on different issues and events (Grimmer, 2013). Moreover, research demonstrates that the news media often quotes large sections of press releases from members of Congress in their articles and newscasts (Bennett, 1990; Grimmer, 2013; Vinson, 2003).

While Twitter and Facebook represent newer forms of communication, they have quickly become a key part of legislators' communication strategy (Hemphill et al., 2021; Russell, 2021). Given that they have fewer gatekeepers and require less editing than other forms of communication, Twitter and Facebook are a more direct form of outreach (Graham et al., 2018). Moreover, Twitter is particularly important to African Americans given their disproportionate use of the platform (Tillery, 2019). However, Twitter is a social media site that tends to skew younger and more liberal (Pew Research). To ensure that anger is used as part of a broader communication strategy, we also explore Facebook posts. Almost two-thirds of Americans have a Facebook account, and the demographics of Facebook users are closer to that of the total United States population than Twitter users (Pew Research).

ESTIMATING CHANGE IN ANGER IN OUTREACH OVER TIME

We use a regression discontinuity in time (Hausman & Rapson, 2018) to explore the change in anger in elected officials' communication following the murder of George Floyd. This strategy has been used in recent research to explore the impact of the Floyd murder and ensuing protests on attitudes toward the police (Reny & Newman, 2021). Regression discontinuity in time

³We collected each form of media at the end of the congressional session on January 2, 2021. Given that our RDIT analysis is bandwidth 6–7 months before this date, almost all information except for deleted press releases, Tweets, or Facebook posts should be included in the analysis.

uses a panel of respondents, in our case members of Congress, and uses time as the running variable. The cutoff point is the date of an important event.

By focusing on press releases, Facebook posts, and Tweets immediately preceding and following a key event for the same sets of individuals, regression discontinuity in time provides a quasi-natural experiment where communications before the cutoff date and after are similar in most ways but differ by the presence of a significant exogenous change. Any immediate change in outcomes is therefore interpreted as the treatment effect.⁴

We explore whether there was a sudden change in expressions of anger around the cutoff of May 27, 2020—the day after the video of Floyd's murder was released—in press releases, Facebook posts, and Tweets. As discussed by Reny and Newman (2021), who use the same cutoff date, the unanticipated murder of Floyd provides an exogenous cutoff which can be leveraged to examine whether events that produce anger among African Americans in the population also produce displays of anger among elected officials. We expect to find that across the communication mediums, Black representatives exhibit the largest post-cutoff increase in angry expressions, mirroring the significant increase in anger among the Black population during this time period.

The fact that members of Congress collectively put out hundreds of Tweets, Facebook posts, and press releases daily provides enough cases to explore nuanced changes in language over time and around our key date. In our estimates, we use the mean square error optimal bandwidth around the cutoff, as suggested by Calonico et al. (2014). Moreover, we use a linear time trend on either side, which provides fewer erratic results than higher level polynomials (see Calonico et al., 2015). Our results are robust to polynomial in time of orders of 2, 3, and 4 and to using twice the optimal bandwidth. Results are generally robust to using half the optimal bandwidth, although here some coefficients lose significance when using the robust p-values.

We use sentiment analysis from the Linguistic in Word Counts (LIWC) dictionary to categorize three emotions: anger, anxiety, and sadness. Anger represents our emotion of interest, but we also test two other negative emotions to demonstrate that the Floyd murder had a unique effect on anger as opposed to other negative emotions. LIWC codes words that psychologists and linguists associate with anger, including “frustrated,” “fighting,” “hate,” and “pissed” among others, which tap into a similar emotion as anger-based words. LIWC codes words like “grief,” “cry,” and “sad” as being sadness-based words. Finally, words like “nervous,” “afraid,” and “tense” are coded as anxiety-based words. This approach to measure the valence of messaging has been validated by numerous social scientists and is routinely used in political science research (Donohue et al., 2020; Gleason et al., 2019; Young & Soroka, 2012). Our dependent variable of interest is the percent of anger, anxiety, or sadness-based words in each press release, Facebook post, or tweet released during our period of interest.⁵

We estimate the models using the complete corpus of press releases, Facebook posts, and Tweets instead of just focusing on a subset of these communications centered on Black Lives Matter for several reasons. First, theoretically, given that anger as an emotion is likely to spillover to other areas, we anticipate that emotional matching should not be confined

⁴We find resonance between our study and recent work by Cormack and Gulati (2024), who examine legislators' public expressions of support for or opposition to BLM in the wake of the Floyd murder across e-newsletters, Facebook, Twitter, and press releases. Their analyses find no evidence that the race of the legislator or the racial make-up of the legislator's district significantly influences signals of support or opposition relating to the movement. Yet we uncover notable differences across legislators' race in emotional expressions following Floyd's death, underscoring that racial differences can emerge in the tone of elites' messaging rather than the content.

⁵This measure is only observed when a Member of Congress posts, but we arrive at the same results if we replace days with no posts as scores of 0 on the anger scale. See [online Appendix](#).

to a specific set of issues (Sears et al., 2016; Yegiyani, 2015). Second, practically, there are too few press releases and Facebook posts which mention Black Lives Matter or related topics prior to Floyd's murder to adequately estimate changes in anger in these outlets over time. Using a broad dictionary of Black Lives Matter names and related topics (see [online Appendix](#) for dictionary), we can estimate changes in anger for Black and White elected officials on Twitter. However, even here caution should be taken in interpreting the results given the very large confidence intervals and smaller sample size. Nonetheless, we find that both Black and White elected officials use more anger-based terms following the murder of George Floyd in Black Lives Matter-related Tweets and non-Black Lives Matter-related Tweets (see [online Appendix](#)).

RESULTS

[Figure 1](#) presents the results of 27 different Regression Discontinuity in Time (RDiT) models predicting changes in anger-based words, sadness-based words, and anxiety-based words in A: Press Releases, B: Facebook Posts, and C: Tweets. Each model is estimated separately for

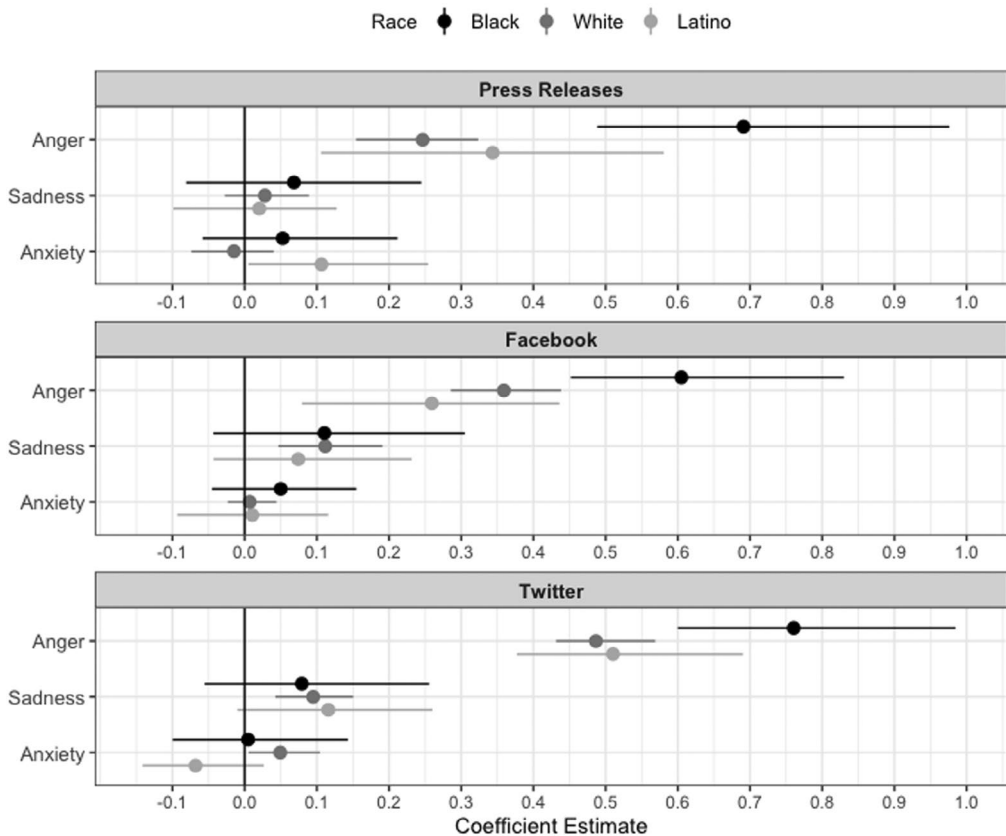


FIGURE 1 Regression discontinuity in time analysis predicting changes in anger, sadness, and anxiety-based words in press releases, Facebook posts, and Tweets for Black, White, and Latino/a Members of Congress. RDiT Estimates With 95% confidence intervals. See full table in Page 1 of the [online Appendix](#). Press Release-N (Black Representatives-4521| White Representatives-26,532| Latino/a Representatives-3456), Facebook-N (Black Representatives-20,821| White Representatives-146,922| Latino/a Representatives-22,449), Twitter N (Black Representatives-39,736| White Representatives-228,844| Latino/a Representatives-36,778).

Black, White, and Latino/a US House Representatives.⁶ Each graph presents the RDiT estimate along with 95% confidence intervals using robust standard errors. Given the large sample size, in all cases the bandwidths are within 27 days of the event, allowing for more precise estimates of the impacts of interest.

The results across all three platforms are consistent and confirm our first hypothesis that Black members of Congress, like Black people in the public (see Eichstaedt et al., 2021), expressed the largest increase in feelings of anger following the murder of George Floyd. Moreover, we largely find that White and Latino/a legislators increase in their expressions of anger similar to their co-racial and co-ethnic counterparts in the population. Moreover, this increase in expressions of anger is smaller than the changes in anger among Black elected officials. Thus, while we focus on African Americans, the results indicate that descriptive representatives of all races mirror the emotions of their respective shared-race constituencies.

Press releases issued by African American legislators used a higher percentage of anger-based words immediately following the Floyd murder. The increase of more than two-thirds of a percentage point (.69), more than doubles the percent of anger-based words used by Black representatives before the event. This increase is statistically significant at the .01 level. Moreover, it is significantly greater than the increases in use of anger-based words by White and Latino/a Members of Congress, despite similar averages before the cutoff. After Floyd's murder, White representatives increased the percent of anger-based words in their press releases by .24 percentage points, and Latino/a Members of Congress increased by .34 percentage points, both significant at .01.

We find a similar relationship when turning to social media. After George Floyd's murder, Black members of Congress increased their use of anger-based words on Facebook by .61 percentage points. Similar to the press releases, this increase in expressions of anger among Black elected officials is significantly greater than the increase in the percentage of anger-based words in Facebook posts from White (.35) and Latino/a (.26) members of Congress, despite similar averages among all three groups prior to Floyd's murder.⁷

Figure 1 also shows that there is a .76 percentage-point increase in anger-based words in Black elected officials' Tweets immediately following the murder of George Floyd, a change that is statistically significant at .01. The increase in percentage of anger-based words for Black representatives during this period is significantly greater than the increases for White (.49) and Latino/a (.51) members of Congress. These effects represent an approximate increase of 100% over the average levels of anger-based words before Floyd's murder for White and Latino/a representatives, and an increase of nearly 150% for Black representatives. Across traditional and non-traditional modes of communication, Black members of Congress express higher levels of anger following the murder of George Floyd than all other racial groups. This supports our argument that Black elected officials were the most likely to share the emotional response to the Floyd murder as Black people in the population.

We re-ran the analyses with party affiliation and the demographic characteristics of the Representative's district, respectively, in lieu of Representative race as the dependent variable. Neither the Representative's party nor the makeup of their district is significantly associated with spikes in expressions of anger post-cutoff. Further, the effects for Representative race are

⁶We find that generally White Democrats and White Republicans largely do not differ in their changes in expressions of anger following Floyd's death. The only exception to this is that White Democrats express more anger on Twitter as a result of Floyd's murder than White Republicans. There is only a single Black Republican in the US House in the 116th Congress. As a result, we cannot explore partisan differences among Black elected officials.

⁷In the online Appendix, we show that there are not significant differences between men's and women's emotional responses to the murder of Floyd regardless of the race of the elected official. The one exception to this is that White women in press releases display more anger than White men.

robust to inclusion of party and district characteristics as covariates in the main RD analyses. Thus, we are confident that our effects for Black representatives are not driven by party or district effects. Representative race is the critical factor in the mirroring of emotions of one's shared-race constituency.⁸

Anger was found to be the predominant negative emotion expressed by Congress members, consistent with initial expectations. No other emotion was expressed as consistently as anger following the murder of George Floyd. Black representatives did not express significantly more sadness or anxiety in the choice of their words before and after the murder of George Floyd across any of the platforms we analyze. While other negative emotions grew significantly among White and Latino/a elected officials,⁹ no emotion consistently changed as much as anger among these groups.

In sum, our findings provide support for our expectations. In the immediate aftermath of the Floyd murder, the public messaging of Black representatives exhibits significant increases in angry expressions, mirroring the uptick in anger reported by African Americans during this period. Black elites' anger outpaces both expressions of anger by their White and Latina/o counterparts and their expressions of other negative emotions. This study is unable to pinpoint whether the mirroring of Black constituents' emotions by descriptively representative elites is rooted in natural affinity, conscious choice, or contagion; opening the door for future work to uncover the precise pathways through which such mirroring can occur. Yet, we demonstrate that Black representatives are effectively mirroring the dominant emotion of their shared-race constituency. Our experimental study reveals the potential consequences of this mirroring.

EXPERIMENTAL ANALYSIS

To better understand whether this emotional connection has political implications for Black people's perceptions of their legislators, we administered an experiment to 400 Black respondents on Prolific in the Spring of 2022.¹⁰ Peer et al. (2022) explored different survey platforms across four measures including attention, comprehension, honesty, and reliability. They found that only Prolific respondents scored high in each one of these measures, indicating that Prolific provides high quality data. In fact, in our own sample, only 2 percent of respondents failed attention checks.¹¹

Our experiment was administered in two stages. In the first stage, we worked to increase feelings of anger among our Black respondents by presenting them three pictures of police violence (see [online Appendix](#) for photos). We selected the images of police violence and presented them in this fashion to simulate the anger that African Americans felt when finding out about the police violence used against George Floyd in the Summer of 2020. Given the sensitive nature of the images, in the consent form we warn participants who may be triggered by the

⁸In [Figure S1](#) of the [online Appendix](#), we also estimate whether Black legislators use more anger-based words in communication if they represent majority Black districts or not. In press releases and on Facebook, Black members of Congress express similar levels of anger regardless of the percent of Black people in their district. On Twitter, Black members in majority Black districts increase in anger at a significantly greater rate than other Black representatives.

⁹In Facebook posts (.11%) and Tweets (.09%), White members of Congress used significantly more sadness-based words in the days after the murder of George Floyd than before this incident. White politicians also used .05% more anxiety-based words in their Tweets in the days following Floyd's death than before. Finally, Latino/a elected officials used .10% more anxiety-based words in their press releases around Floyd's death than before.

¹⁰As required by Oregon State University (Stout's Previous Institution were IRB was obtained), following the debriefing statement, we asked respondents whether they would like to continue to be included in the study. Ten respondents opted not to take part in the survey after hearing information about the study.

¹¹While we do not remove individuals who failed the attention checks, in the [Supplemental Appendix](#) we show that we arrive at the same results if we do.

photos that the survey contains images that may be upsetting to some, as they depict forms of violence and protests. We also tell respondents they can leave the survey at any point if they are feeling uncomfortable. While alternate approaches can be used to prime anger, such as asking people to write about a time when they were angry, even these approaches are not without the risk of being triggering, and they may be less directly tied to our event of interest.

To measure change in mood, we asked respondents “How Angry/Sad/Anxious do you feel right now” before and after the pictures were presented. The responses to these questions were measured on a five-point scale which ranged from 1—“Not Angry/Sad/Anxious at all” to 5—“Very Angry/Sad/Anxious.” Using a pre-post design allows us to measure how the stimulus shapes individuals’ moods (Clifford et al., 2021). While our measures of respondents’ emotions are not derived from Rhodes-Purdy et al.’s (2021) modified Positive and Negative Affect Schedule (PANAS), we heed their call to consider that multiple negative emotions can be primed simultaneously by a threatening stimulus. Accordingly, while we focus on how respondents evaluate elites who mirror their anger, we offer respondents the opportunity to report changes in sadness and anxiety in response to the prompts as well. We expect that similar to Study 1 and aforementioned extant work, anger will be the dominant response to exposure to the treatment.

Following this first stage of the experiment, we then presented all respondents with the same description of a hypothetical elected official. To focus on the influence of shared emotional responses, the race of the elected official is not mentioned and the politician is given a racially ambiguous name. In the previous section, we focused on identifying legislators who react to salient events in the same emotional manner as Black people. In this section, we are interested in exploring whether Black people feel more positively about elected officials who share their emotional response to police violence. This is not to say that this interaction of the race of the messenger and the message is not important, merely that our interest is in whether people feel better about politicians who match their emotions at a given time. Respondents were asked to read the following profile and were told it described an elected official in their area. The description read as follows:

Representative J. Perry is an elected official in your area who focuses on increasing the minimum wage and advancing the interest of working-class and middle-class families. Representative J. Perry has been a high-ranking official on the Ways and Means committee of the U.S. House of Representatives and has served in Congress for 6 years.

Following this information we randomly assigned respondents into one of three categories. The first was simply the description above (or the baseline), the second group was presented with the above information and a tweet which included more anger based words, and the final tweet included the information above and a sadness based tweet. To ensure the anger and sadness Tweets were affectively laden, we intentionally designed them using words associated with either anger or sadness as defined in the LIWC dictionary. The angry Tweet displayed the message, “I am angry about the brutal murders of Black people by law enforcement. We will fight to ensure justice for all”. The sadness Tweet displayed the message, “I am saddened by the loss of Black people at the hands of law enforcement. We will work to ensure justice for all”.

Following this information, we asked respondents, “How Much Do You Approve of Representative J. Perry?” “How Much Do You Trust Representative J. Perry to represent your interests in Congress?” and “How Much Do You Believe that Representative J. Perry Cares About People Like You?” The possible responses to each one of these questions ranged from 1—“Not at All” to 5—“A Great Deal.”¹² We use this data to run two different analyses. In the

¹²We find covariate balance with regards to gender, age, income, education, and partisanship across treatment conditions. See Supplemental Appendix.

first analysis, we estimate attitudes about the hypothetical politician among people who expressed an increase in anger following the presentation of police violence images and separately among people who expressed no change or decline in anger after viewing these images. This allows us to determine whether anger specific to police violence moderates the effects of the messaging tied to this issue.

We dichotomize this relationship because changes in levels of anger may be subjective and respondent specific. Relatedly, it is difficult to discern whether someone who moved from an anger level of 2 to 3 (a 1 point change) is truly only half as angry as someone whose anger levels change from 1 to 3 (a 2 point change) after being presented the photograph. Instead, this model simply identifies people who become more angry after viewing images of police violence. We expect to find that respondents who report an increase in anger after exposure to the treatment will rate the hypothetical candidate who mirrors their anger as more trustworthy, empathetic, and worthy of higher approval. These higher evaluations will be relative to both respondents who report increased anger yet read about candidates who do not mirror this anger.

Our second estimation explores whether levels of anger on our 5-point scale after the presentation of police violence photos moderates the effect of the treatment on attitudes about the elected official. This model accounts for ceiling effects in difference in levels of anger before and after the presentation of images. The change in anger model listed above treats a respondent who moved from a 4 to a 5 on our anger scale as being equal to someone who moved from a score of 1 to a score of 2. We would anticipate, however, that those who are the most angry, regardless of the source of this anger, should feel more positively about elected officials who share this emotion in their outreach.

Figure 2 presents the results of six OLS regressions predicting A: approval of the hypothetical elected official, B: perceptions of empathy for the hypothetical elected official, and C: perceptions that the hypothetical elected official will work to advance the constituent's goals in government. The models are estimated separately for respondents who reported an increase in anger as a result of the photos of police violence and respondents who had no change in anger or decreased in anger following this information. The figures include the point estimates and 95% confidence intervals, with the baseline elected official serving as the reference (i.e., the zero line).

The results in Figure 2 provide support for our hypothesis that African Americans derive positive feelings about elected officials and increase perceptions that they are empathetic and trustworthy when those officials share their dominant emotions. Black respondents who expressed an increase in anger after viewing the photos were .55 points more approving of the representative who expressed anger in their Tweets compared to the baseline representative. They were also .43 points more approving of the representative who used anger in their Tweets compared to the representative who used sadness as their core emotional response to Floyd's murder. Both differences are statistically significant at .05. In contrast, there was no statistically significant difference in approval for the baseline representative and the representative who responded using sadness-based words among those who expressed an increase in anger after viewing the photos.

Additionally, the gap in approval between the baseline representative and the anger-based representative is only marginally significant ($p < .10$) for African American respondents who reported no change in anger or less anger following pictures of police violence. This group of respondents was also not significantly different in their levels of approval for elected officials who responded to Floyd's murder using anger or sadness-based words.

Black respondents who became angrier as a result of the photos depicting police violence were also significantly more likely to believe that the politician who evoked anger in their Tweet cared about people like them and was more trustworthy. Specifically, Black respondents who increased in anger following the pictures of police violence were .57 points more likely to perceive the representative who responded to Floyd's death with anger-based words as more

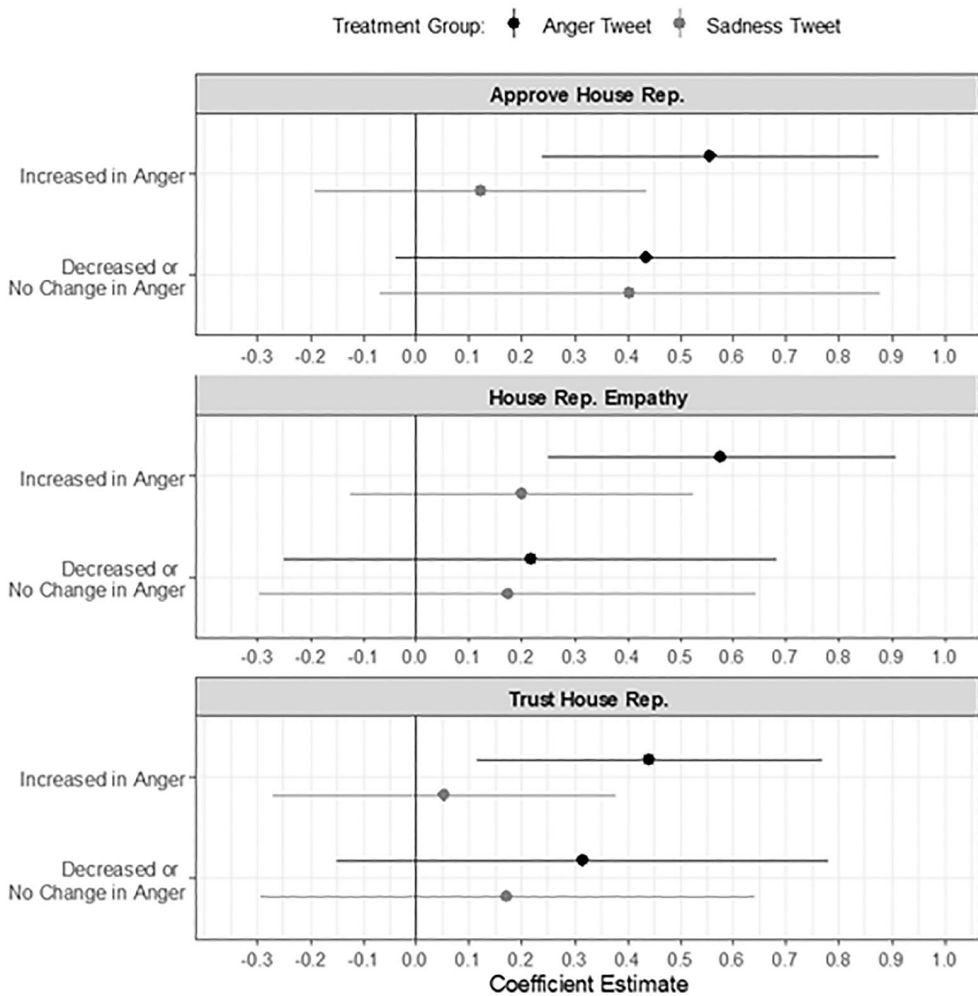


FIGURE 2 OLS regression estimates for approval of hypothetical elected official, perceptions of empathy of elected official, and trust in representative to advance respondent's interest. The Estimates above present OLS regression estimates with 95% confidence intervals. Only Black respondents are included in this sample. Increased in anger- $N=253$, decrease/no change in anger- $N=137$. See full table in Page 2 of the [online Appendix](#).

empathetic, compared to the baseline representative. And they were .47 points more likely to perceive the representative who used anger-based words as empathetic than the representative who responded to Floyd's murder using sadness-based words. Both differences are statistically significant at .05. Black respondents who did not increase in their anger following the photos did not rate the baseline representative as being significantly different from the representatives who used anger or sadness-based words in their Tweets.

Finally, Black respondents who experience an increase in anger are significantly more likely to trust the elected official to represent their interests in Congress when they tweet anger-based words in response to Floyd's murder, compared to both the baseline representative (.44 points more) and the representative who used sadness-based words (.39 points more). In contrast, when respondents do not report an increase in anger following images of police violence, there are no statistically significant differences in trust in elected officials, regardless of the emotional tone used in the official's Tweet.

TABLE 1 OLS regression predicting attitudes about elected officials by treatment type and post-image anger levels.

	Approve rep	Trust rep	Rep empathetic
Anger treat	.488* (.259)	.341 (.259)	.260 (.261)
Sad treat	.541** (.264)	.401 (.264)	.330 (.266)
Anger level 2	.139 (.266)	.0214 (.268)	-.171 (.268)
Anger level 3	.462 (.287)	.536* (.287)	.203 (.290)
Anger level 4	.625** (.294)	.786*** (.294)	.607** (.296)
Anger level 5	.294 (.325)	.595* (.325)	.298 (.327)
Anger treat * Anger level 2	.00188 (.360)	.202 (.361)	.382 (.363)
Anger treat * Anger level 3	-.222 (.401)	-.250 (.401)	-.197 (.404)
Anger treat * Anger level 4	-.175 (.428)	-.0281 (.428)	.0529 (.431)
Anger treat * Anger level 5	.910* (.467)	.601 (.467)	1.107** (.471)
Sad treat * Anger level 2	-.562 (.366)	-.445 (.367)	-.126 (.368)
Sad treat * Anger level 3	-.473 (.381)	-.522 (.383)	-.265 (.384)
Sad treat * Anger level 4	-.451 (.443)	-.293 (.443)	-.152 (.446)
Sad treat * Anger level 5	.165 (.497)	-.0594 (.497)	.0287 (.501)
Constant	3.000*** (.199)	2.464*** (.199)	2.643*** (.201)
Observations	387	385	387
R-squared	.097	.112	.108

Note: Standard errors in parentheses.

*** $p < .01$; ** $p < .05$; * $p < .1$.

Table 1 examines how treatment effects and anger levels (measured on a five-point scale after viewing images of police violence) interact to shape attitudes toward the hypothetical elected official. This analysis allows us to measure whether those who expressed the most anger after the presentation of the photos responded differently to the emotion-related outreach of the hypothetical member of Congress.

According to Table 1, Black people who expressed the highest amount of anger (Score of 5) were marginally significantly more approving of the elected official ($p = .052$) and perceived the elected official as more caring ($p = .02$) when the elected official used anger-based words in

comparison to those who had the lowest levels of expressed anger. Moreover, Black people who expressed the most anger were significantly more likely to approve of the elected official and found them to be more empathetic when they used anger-based words than those at the same level of anger who were read about the politician who used sadness-based words or made no statement at all.¹³

Those with the highest levels of anger were not significantly more likely to perceive the elected official as being trustworthy when they used anger-based words than Black respondents with the lowest levels of anger. With some caveats, our results are consistent with our expectations. Namely, when representatives share the dominant emotions of their constituents, they are viewed as more empathetic and generally rated more favorably.

CONCLUSION

While it is well documented that what politicians say to their constituents matters (Gillion, 2016; Harris, 2012; Tate, 2003), our research demonstrates that how they say it is also important. In our experimental analysis, we find evidence that constituents feel better about elected officials who mirror their emotions in their interactions with the public. Moreover, we show that descriptive representatives are uniquely adept at matching the emotions of their co-racial constituents.

Our data show that like African Americans in the population (Eichstaedt et al., 2021), Black members of Congress expressed the most anger after the murder of George Floyd in their public communication via Twitter, Facebook, and press releases. While not the focus of this study, our analysis also finds that White and Latino/a legislators mirrored their co-racial and co-ethnic counterparts in the population by expressing smaller changes in anger in their public communication following this critical event. Taken together, our findings demonstrate that descriptive representatives do a better job than non-descriptive elected officials at mirroring the emotions of their co-racial constituents. In addition to providing better substantive representation and symbolic representation (Dietrich & Hayes, 2023; Tate, 2003), our research suggests that elected officials may also best share the emotions of their co-racial constituents.

Elected officials who expressed anger following the murder of George Floyd likely received an increase in support among African Americans. Our experimental results provide evidence that constituents are more favorable toward elected officials who mirror their emotions through their communication. Employing a two-stage study, we found that elected officials who mirror the anger of their constituents receive higher levels of approval, are perceived as more empathetic, and in some cases are more trusted to represent the interests of their constituents. These results show that emotional mirroring is more than just symbolic; it can have real-world consequences in improving perceptions of the elected official.

While this study provides some insight into which elected officials emotionally mirror underrepresented groups and whether this matters, more work is necessary. First, future research should explore instances in which public officials have opportunities to mirror emotions other than anger. For example, future work can examine whether the death of prominent Black figures or a rise in hate crimes against Asian Americans leads to a greater expression of sadness or anxiety among both the population and among descriptive elected officials. Moreover, future research should explore whether all forms of emotional mirroring from elected officials are equally effective. For instance, would voters be appreciative of an elected official who

¹³The effect of candidate empathy on approval is strongest among Black respondents with high anger levels, whether anger is measured continuously or categorically. The interaction between anger and treatment is not significant due to minimal differences across lower anger levels. See [online appendix](#) for the marginal effects graph.

mirrors their anxiety with the same nervous energy, or would representing this emotion engender less favorability toward the elected official relative to mirroring an action-oriented emotion such as anger?

Second, more work needs to be done to determine whether our results in a controlled setting hold in the real world. While our random assignment of individuals to elected officials who share their emotions provides internal validity between emotional mirroring and attitudes about elected officials, future work should explore whether this relationship holds in the real world. Third, future research should empirically identify the mechanisms that lead descriptive representatives to better mirror the emotions of co-racial/ethnic people in the population. In this study, we argue that descriptive representation should matter most, given that the personal experiences of the elected official make them naturally better at mirroring their constituents and the inherent value they perceive in providing emotional matching for their co-racial constituents.

However, other factors, such as the percentage of a group in the district, may influence the levels of emotional mirroring. While in the [online Appendix](#) we find some support that majority Black districts lead to higher levels of emotional matching with regards to anger following the murder of George Floyd for Black and non-Black members, it is not as consistent a predictor of emotional matching as descriptive representation. As a result, it is likely that one reason descriptive representatives provide better emotional responsiveness is that their reactions to key moments naturally mirror those who share their identity. Nonetheless, more work is necessary to identify the mechanism tied to the emotional matching we find in this study.

Third, future research should assess whether people respond differently to emotional matching when it comes from descriptive or non-descriptive representatives. While we show that Black respondents are more supportive of an elected official who shares their emotions in their outreach, it is possible that these effects may be moderated by the race of the messenger (Garcia & Stout, 2022). This may be particularly true given that African American elected officials may face greater risks for speaking out, which may be noted by co-racial constituents. Future inquiries can further illuminate the potential manners through which emotional matching engenders stronger ties between elites and everyday people while fostering their political engagement.

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DATA AVAILABILITY STATEMENT

The data that support the findings of this study are openly available in Representing Emotion-Harvard Dataverse at <https://doi.org/10.7910/DVN/RRRZC1>.

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SUPPORTING INFORMATION

Additional supporting information can be found online in the Supporting Information section at the end of this article.

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